

A Day in Toulouse

Toulouse is pretty, prosperous, and rich in culture. Known as *La Ville Rose* (the Pink City), the Place du Capitole lies at its heart; head here for a relaxing coffee and people-watching between visiting sights.

MORNING Visit the **Théâtre du Capitole** to marvel at its painted ceilings. From there walk the **rue du Taur** to Europe's largest Romanesque church, **St Sernin Basilica**.

AFTERNOON Explore the fortress-like **Jacobins Convent**, with its soaring "palm tree" pillars and vaults. Call into the **Musée des Augustins**, a 14th-century convent, for Gothic statuary. Contrast the old with the new at **Les Abbatoirs**, where more than 2,000 pieces of modern art are housed in what was a 19th-century slaughterhouse.

EVENING Come sunset, take up a seat on the terrace in **Place du Capitole** and watch the 18th-century red-brick buildings that cast a rosy tint by day begin to blush and glow lilac as dusk falls. Wander along the banks of the **Garonne River** to see the vaults of the old **New Bridge** lit up at night.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Aéroport Toulouse Blagnac is a 7-mile (11-km) drive or bus ride from the city, and has flights to most major European cities. There are also **high-speed trains** from Paris and Lille.

WHERE TO STAY

Le Clos des Potiers (inexpensive) is a refined retreat with Empire style and plenty of atmosphere. www.hotel-closdespotiers.com
Hôtel Le Grand Balcon (moderate) is a 1930s hotel, much loved by French author Antoine de Saint-Exupéry, and now completely renovated. www.grandbalconhotel.com

Grand Hôtel de l'Opéra (expensive) is a former 17th-century convent-turned-plush hotel on the Place du Capitole. www.grand-hotel-opera.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

Donjon du Capitole; www.toulouse-tourisme.com



Right The Toulouse version of cassoulet always includes garlicky sausage and either goose or duck

Below Dining alfresco in the Place du Capitole, which hosts a market on Saturdays

